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From 5 Indians to 5% of Population: Diaspora Key to Seychelles Ties

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New Delhi, June 26

IT WAS in 1770 that five Indians landed in Seychelles as plantation workers, along with seven African slaves and 15 French colonists, recorded as the first inhabitants of the Islands located in the Indian Ocean. Today, persons of Indian origin comprise 5% of the island nation's population.

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi heads to Seychelles on a three-day visit beginning Saturday, here is a look at the ties that bind the two countries located 4,000 km apart.

Migration and trade

It was from the 20th century that a constant flow of Indians, mostly from Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and later Gujarat, came to reside in Seychelles as traders, labourers and construction workers.

In fact, during the British colonial period, Seychelles was governed from the Bombay Presidency for some time, with regular shipping and flow of goods from

India. These trade links facilitated the migration of an Indian trading community looking for greener pastures, having reached a saturation point in East Africa.

The number of Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs) with Seychelles citizenship is estimated at around 6,000 presently, which is significant in a country with a population of about 120,000. A majority belong to the Gujarati and the Tamil communities.

Diplomatic relations

When Seychelles attained freedom on June 29, 1976, a contingent from the Indian Naval Ship, INS Nilgiri, took part in the Independence Day celebrations. This year, as PM Modi is attending the 50th Independence Day celebrations as the Guest of Honour, an Indian Armed Forces contingent and two Indian Navy ships are participating as well.

Diplomatic ties were established with Seychelles in 1976. Earlier this year, Modi also described Seychelles as a key part of India's maritime policy — Vision MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Se-

Global south strategy

● Seychelles is an important part of India's Global South strategy, serving as a critical maritime partner in the Western Indian Ocean.

● The island nation also helps India combat seaborne terrorism, piracy, and illegal fishing.

● Situated close to Africa, the Middle East, and Asia, Seychelles serves as a vital counterweight against China's expanding influence in the Indian Ocean.

curity and Growth Across Regions).

Cultural ties

With a significant Indian diaspora, cultural contacts have been primarily community-driven. In June 2022, a statue of Mahatma Gandhi was erected at the Peace Park in Victoria, which also had statues of Nelson Mandela, the first President of South Africa and Sir James Mancham, the founding President of Seychelles.

Today, the Indian-origin community is visible in all walks of life, but mostly dominating the trading and construction sectors. There are also over 9,000 NRIs holding Gainful Employment Permits, working in the construction sector, as shop assistants and as professionals.

In 2015, the Pravasi Bharatiya Samman Award was conferred on Justice D Karunakaran of the Supreme Court of Seychelles, becoming the second recipient from the country after V Ramadoss (2006), an entrepreneur and medical advisor to the Seychelles President.

PM's visit

PM Modi had earlier visited Seychelles in 2015, while the first Indian PM to visit Seychelles was Indira Gandhi in 1981. During his three-day visit, Modi will address the National Assembly of Seychelles and interact with members of the Indian community. Beyond cultural relations, India has emerged as one of Seychelles' most trusted development partners through grants, concessional credit and capacity-building initiatives. More than 1% of Seychelles' population has received professional training in India.

Over the years, New Delhi has extended significant Lines of Credit and grant assistance supporting infrastructure, healthcare, education and public transport.

This year, Modi also announced a Special Economic Package of \$175 million for Seychelles. India also continues to be a premier medical tourism destination for Seychelles, with institutional tie-ups connecting island hospitals with facilities in cities like Chennai.

From 5 Indians to 5% of Population: Diaspora Key to Seychelles Ties

● Historical Roots

- In 1770, five Indians landed in Seychelles as plantation workers, along with seven African slaves and 15 French colonists recorded as the first inhabitants of the islands
- Today, persons of Indian origin comprise about 5% of Seychelles' population

Operation Flowers are Blooming (1986): India actively supported the stability of Seychelles. In June 1986, the Indian Navy deployed INS Vindhyagiri to Victoria to help abort an attempted coup against President France-Albert René.

From 5 Indians to 5% of Population: Diaspora Key to Seychelles Ties

● Migration & Trade

- A constant flow of Indians mostly from Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, and later Gujarat began residing in Seychelles as traders, labourers and construction workers from the 20th century
- During the **British colonial period, Seychelles was governed from the Bombay Presidency** for a time, with shipping/trade links facilitating Indian migration as the trading community in East Africa reached saturation

● Diplomatic & Strategic Relations

- Diplomatic ties were established in 1976, the year Seychelles attained freedom (June 29, 1976); **INS Nilgiri** took part in that year's Independence Day celebrations
- This year, PM Modi attends the **50th Independence Day celebrations as Guest of Honour**, with an Indian Armed Forces contingent and two Indian Navy ships also participating
- Modi has described Seychelles as a key part of India's maritime policy Vision **MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions)**

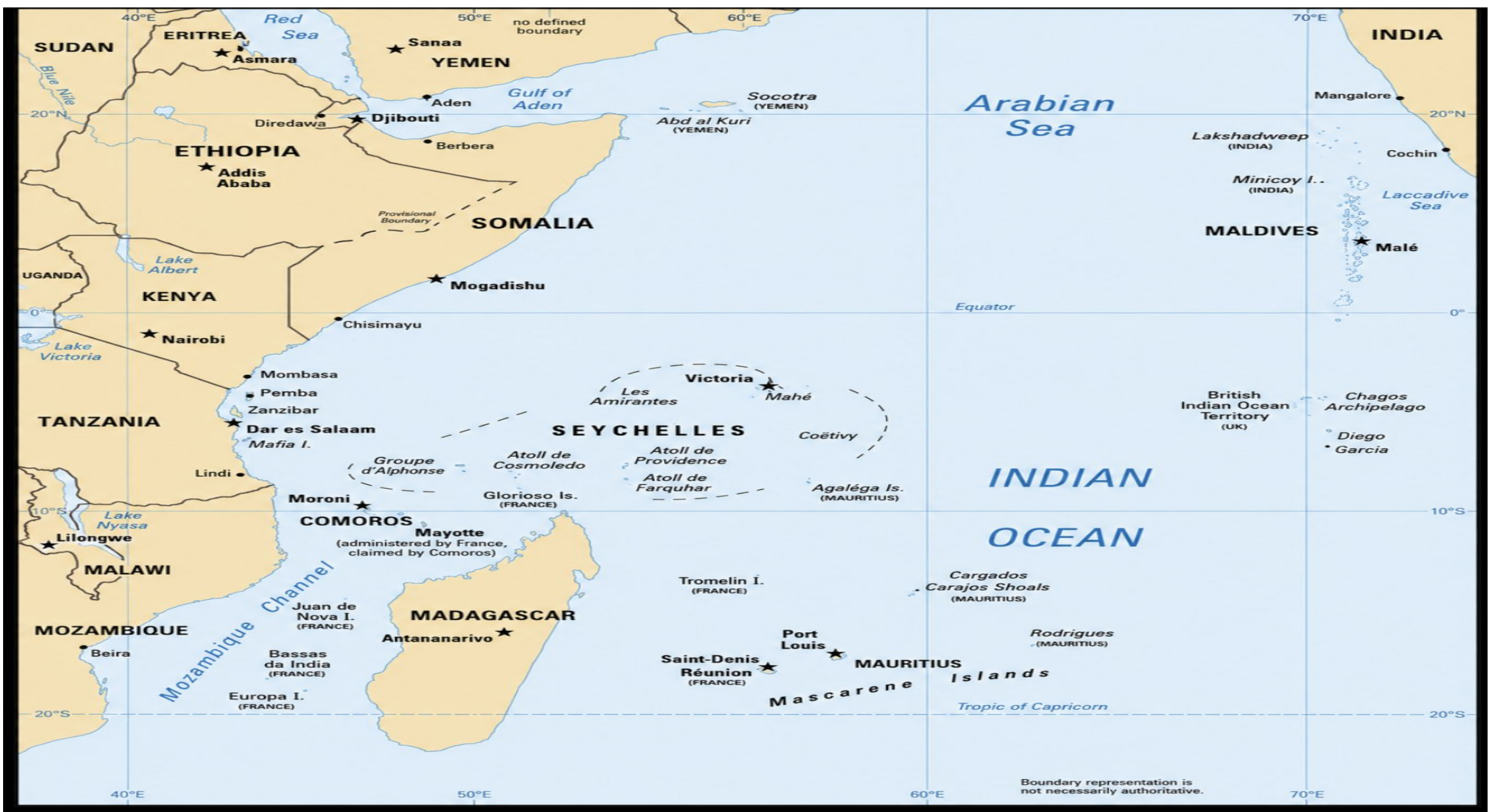
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● **Cultural Ties & Development Partnership**

- A **statue of Mahatma Gandhi was erected at the Peace Park in Victoria in June 2022**, alongside statues of Nelson Mandela and Sir James Mancham (Seychelles' founding President)
- In 2015, the Pravasi Bharatiya Samman Award was conferred on Justice D Karunakaran of the Supreme Court of Seychelles, the second recipient from the country
- India has extended **Lines of Credit and grant assistance** for infrastructure, healthcare, education and public transport; over 1% of Seychelles' population has received professional training in India; India is a premier medical tourism destination for Seychelles

● **PM's Visit**

- PM Modi first visited Seychelles in 2015; the first Indian PM to visit was Indira Gandhi in 1981
- During this three-day visit, Modi will address the National Assembly of Seychelles and has announced a Special Economic Package of \$175 million for Seychelles



Locations :

- **Maldives**
- **Mauritius**
 - **Chagos Island:**
 - **The Chagos Archipelago** consists of over 60 small islands located in the central Indian Ocean, south of the Maldives, and east of Seychelles. The largest island, Diego Garcia, hosts a key US-UK military base.
 - **UK–Mauritius Chagos Sovereignty Deal (2025):** After a UK High Court ruling, England Prime Minister signed a treaty handing sovereignty of the Chagos Islands to Mauritius. The deal includes a 99-year lease of Diego Garcia to the UK and US for continued military use. **The UK will pay Mauritius approximately £101 million/year, totalling billions over the lease period**
 - **Agalega Island:** India, under a bilateral agreement with Mauritius, has constructed a 3,000-meter-long airstrip and deep-sea jetty on Agalega.
- **Seychelles**
 - **Assumption Islands**
- **Comoros**
- **France**
 - **Mayotte**
 - **Reunion Islands ;** The Island is home to one of the world's most active volcanoes, the Piton de la Fournaise which is also a World Heritage site.

From 5 Indians to 5% of Population: Diaspora Key to Seychelles Ties

Seychelles

It is an archipelagic island country located in the western Indian Ocean. It consists of an archipelago of 115 islands (only 8 are permanently inhabited).

It is Africa's smallest and least populated country.

Capital: Victoria

Strategic Importance for India:

It sits along crucial maritime trade routes in the Indian Ocean and plays a key role in anti-piracy operations, maritime security, and the Blue Economy.

LAMITYE- TriLateral Military Exercise between India and Seychelles

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‘Vanilla Islands’

Vanilla Islands is a grouping of six island nations in south-west Indian Ocean -Mayotte, Comoros, Mauritius, Seychelles, Reunion and Madagascar.

What a 'Right to Walk' Can Look Like for India

What a 'right to walk' can look like for India



EXPERT EXPLAINS

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LAST WEEK, the Supreme Court recognised walking on demarcated footpaths as a fundamental right and urged the government to introduce a law that declares this right. The two-judge bench's ruling came in a case involving the death of a schoolboy in a road accident.

India has the dubious distinction of having the world's highest number of road accident fatalities. The court identified this as the result of the exclusion of pedestrians in the way roads are built.

The issue of road safety is a type of "elite capture", in which the use of public infrastructure by wealthier people is privileged over the needs of others. Pedestrians and cyclists (along with two-wheeler and public transport users) are more likely to be road accident victims than private car users. They are also likely to be poorer than private car users, and are forced to walk or cycle because they cannot afford any other option. These social divisions are exacerbated by the lack of safe roads. This absence worsens poorer peoples' quality of life and prospects, constrains children's access to school and playtime, and deprives adults of the health and well-being effects of walking in wealthier neighbourhoods.

It is in this context that the right to walk needs to be considered — not just as something to be expected as a part of how roads are built, but rather as a fundamental right guaranteed through the right to "move freely through the territory of India" and the "right to life" under Articles 19(1)(d) and 21 of the Constitution.

But what precisely is the legal import of the right to walk, and how can it have a real effect on the ground? By reading the right to walk into fundamental rights, the court has created a basis for its development. The case at hand had limited scope, but after settling the immediate legal issues, the court asked for it to be relisted as a writ petition. One can expect that the issue of walking will be considered in more specific terms in this subsequent iteration.

• SHRINKING SPACE

Pedestrian deaths in the country have more than doubled in 10 years.



SOURCE: MINISTRY OF ROAD TRANSPORT & HIGHWAYS

Here's a look at some of the directions in which the right to walk can be developed, considering its social and cultural ramifications as well as implementation challenges.

Walking is cultural and social, not just about infrastructure

The Supreme Court has pointed out that "walking is not just motion" but embodies expressional, congregational and associational rights under Article 19(1)(a), Article 19(1)(b) and Article 19(1)(c).

To this, we can add the words of the iconic former mayor of Bogotá, Enrique Peñalosa, who said: "Sidewalks are the relatives of parks and plazas, not of streets." They are for conversations, socialising, doing business and children playing, as much as they are for individual autonomy and mobility.

The pedestrian "right of way" has to respond to the social and biophysical requirements of the human beings who use it. A pavement imagined as a sterile strip of infrastructure is not necessarily safe or comfortable for its users without shade-giving trees, places for rest, food and water, and "eyes on the street". The last of these is a concept developed by the urban theorist Jane Jacobs, who observed that public spaces become safer when more people — residents, shopkeepers, pedestrians, cafe patrons — are around.

When viewed in isolation from its social setting, the right to walk could easily run into conflict with the livelihood rights of hawkers. This, however, is a self-defeating understanding of the ecosystem of walking, which includes cycling, public transport, neighbourhood life and workday



Two-wheelers occupy a footpath on a Delhi bridge. PRAVEEN KHANNA/FILE

The SC has said walking on footpaths is a fundamental right. This right, however, must go beyond engineering solutions to creating inclusive spaces

this, it should be achievable within available budgets and resources. Perfect design-led solutions may have to be sacrificed for making conditions safer and more comfortable for pedestrians on every kind of street.

This is not to say that pedestrian life does not need aesthetic imagination, but that form should follow functionality. It is more critical that people get networks of circulation — from home to the bus, work, school, or the market — rather than small islands of perfectly constructed space. Interventions should prioritise the needs of vulnerable groups and focus on places where there are lots of walkers, such as in the areas around schools, bus stands and train stations, labour chowks and low-income neighbourhoods.

Institutional fragmentation around pedestrian rights

There is a legal and institutional vacuum around the issue of walkability. The Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 imposes duties on motorists vis-à-vis pedestrians, but it is primarily a law for motor vehicles and cannot secure the public rights of pedestrians.

There are, separately, a number of engineering designs and standards of road safety that should be applied in road construction projects, but these are not legally enforceable and fall short of a right for pedestrians.

To end this vacuum, the Supreme Court has sought a standalone framework for pedestrians in which municipalities, development authorities and panchayats are responsible for ensuring the right to walk. It has called for a regulatory structure through which the right can be implemented.

In many states, the current relationship of municipalities to pavements is fragmented into a cluster of different tasks — tree pruning, sweeping, drainage, regulating hawkers — without responsibility for overall outcome. Municipalities also deal with pavements side-by-side with other agencies: development authorities and public works departments construct many of the city roads, and electricity departments and water boards plant their infrastructure all over it (often blocking the way for walkers). The traffic police are responsible for policing the movement of cars, and municipalities run demarcated parking areas, but sometimes neither considers themselves accountable for cars parked on the pavement.

It would be impractical to unify these diverse functions into one administrative agency. It could, however, be the task of the municipality to integrate and pull together the various pieces of the puzzle to ensure a safe and comfortable right of way for walkers.

commutes. Moreover, to interpret a fundamental right in a way that denies the vulnerabilities and lived realities of people would defeat the purpose of the Constitution.

The right to walk should not come at the cost of making people poorer, or by closing off avenues of everyday commerce, rest and refreshment. Social interactions and the exchange of news and views are all part of the life of pavements.

The presence of vendors and shade-giving trees on the roadside might seem inconvenient from an engineering point of view, but they are necessary accompaniments of our street life. Ideally, they should coexist alongside the pedestrian right of way. This is not an impossible task if it is secured through administrative intervention at the street-level, by shifting vending spots a few paces here and there, working around the trees and planning spaces for rest and shade where they are not available.

The right to walk should not be limited to islands

Many of the social and cultural issues around walking are in fact taken into account in a clutch of recent design-led projects such as Chandni Chowk and Ambrobindo Marg in Delhi, Church Street and Gandhi Bazaar in Bengaluru and CG Road in Ahmedabad. But while these interventions are well-intentioned, they tend to be small and intensive projects with limited geographical impact.

The Supreme Court's intervention on this issue nudges us in a different direction, to think about how walking as a fundamental right can be made mainstream and local. For

Whose streets?

When viewed in isolation from its social setting, the right to walk could easily run into conflict with the livelihood rights of hawkers.

But this right should not come at the cost of making people poorer, or by closing off avenues of everyday commerce, rest and refreshment.

What a 'Right to Walk' Can Look Like for India

The Supreme Court recently held that walking on footpaths is a Fundamental Right.

The observation came while hearing a case involving the death of a schoolboy in a road accident.

The Court urged the government to enact a legal framework to protect pedestrians.

India has one of the highest road accident fatalities in the world. Pedestrian deaths have more than doubled in the last decade.

3. Major Problems Identified

A. Vehicle-centric Road Design

B. "Elite Capture" of Public Space : Wealthier private vehicle users receive a disproportionate share of road space.

C. Social Inequality : Low-income groups depend more on walking.

What a 'Right to Walk' Can Look Like for India

Walking is More Than Transportation

Social interaction

Community life

Public health

Economic activity

Children's play

Independence and dignity

Street Vendors and Pedestrian Rights

Vendors should not automatically be treated as obstacles.

They: Support livelihoods, Improve street activity, Increase natural surveillance ("eyes on the street")

Better planning should allow pedestrians and vendors to coexist.

India-China Cooperation Can Make Asian Century a Reality

India-China cooperation can make Asian century a reality



XU WEI

With the centre of global gravity shifting to Asia, relations have transcended the bilateral scope. Our combined contribution to global growth positions us as architects of solutions

THE WORLD stands at a turbulent crossroads. Hegemony, unilateralism and protectionism are exacerbating global deficits in peace, development, security and governance. As the only two nations with populations exceeding 1.4 billion, the complexity of the India-China relationship is unmatched. With the centre of global gravity shifting to Asia, relations have transcended the bilateral scope. Our combined contribution of over 40 per cent to global growth positions us as active architects of solutions. By joining hands, China and India can transform Eastern wisdom into a stabilising force in the world. President Xi Jinping's four global initiatives constitute a coherent framework rooted in our shared philosophical traditions. These initiatives offer practical pathways for synergy between China and India.

The Global Development Initiative (GDI) seeks to put development at the top of the global agenda. This dovetails with India's mission of *Viksit Bharat 2047*. Both nations understand development is an inalienable right. The GDI advocates for green, inclusive growth, urging a move away from zero-sum competition. By aligning our development paradigms, we can ensure that modernisation benefits all.

The Global Security Initiative champions common, comprehensive, cooperative, sustainable security. Its fundamental principles — respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, adherence to the principles of the UN Charter, and the peaceful resolution of disputes — directly echo the Panchsheel (Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence), which India and China pioneered decades ago. For neighbours sharing a vast border, the GSI is a timely reminder that true security cannot be achieved by any single nation at the expense of others. Mutual trust remains the most reliable instrument for managing differences.

The Global Civilisation Initiative advocates respect for the diversity of world civilisations, promoting equality, mutual learning, dialogue, and inclusiveness. This resonates with India's philosophy of *vasudhaiva kutumbakam*. As ancient civilisations that have shaped human history for millennia, we share the wisdom that no single culture holds a monopoly on truth. Through civilisational exchanges and mutual learning, we can overcome estrangement, break the "clash of civilisations" narrative, and build a world where people of all nations understand each other.

The Global Governance Initiative aims to build a more just and equitable global system. Its fundamental task is to uphold the authority and status of the UN; the key lies in major countries demonstrating their responsibilities; and the most pressing task is to close peace and development deficits. No country can achieve development by placing itself outside the global governance system, nor secure its future without international cooperation. Artificial isolation only leads to confrontation.

China and India have the responsibility to safeguard Asia's peace and solidarity. So long as we respect each other's core interests and succeed together, we will inject positive energy into global development, security, civilisation, and governance. Together, we can make the Asian century a reality for all.

The writer is consul-general of the People's Republic of China in Kolkata

India-China Cooperation Can Make Asian Century a Reality

● The Author's Premise

- Opinion piece by Xu Wei, Consul-General of the People's Republic of China in Kolkata presents Beijing's perspective on India-China relations
- Argues that hegemony, unilateralism and protectionism are worsening global deficits in peace, development, security and governance; as the only two nations with populations exceeding 1.4 billion, India and China's combined contribution exceeds 40% of global growth

● China's "Four Global Initiatives" Framework

- Global Development Initiative (GDI): puts development at the top of the global agenda — the author links this to India's own Viksit Bharat 2047 mission, advocating green, inclusive growth over zero-sum competition
- Global Security Initiative (GSI): champions common, comprehensive, cooperative, sustainable security; its principles — respect for sovereignty/territorial integrity, the UN Charter, peaceful dispute resolution — are linked by the author to the Panchsheel (Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence), jointly pioneered by India and China decades ago
- Global Civilisation Initiative: calls for respecting the diversity of world civilisations and mutual learning — the author connects this to India's philosophy of vasudhaiva kutumbakam ("the world is one family")
- Global Governance Initiative: aims to build a more just, equitable global system upholding the authority of the UN

● The Author's Conclusion

- Frames China and India as sharing a "responsibility to safeguard Asia's peace and solidarity," arguing that respecting each other's core interests could "make the Asian century a reality"

'Anyway, It's a Girl' — 45 Years Later, It Still Rankles



MANMOHAN BAHADUR

THE LATEST SRS 2024 (Sample Registration System) population data is a cause for worry for the national drive to protect the girl child. From 952 female births to 1,000 male deliveries in 1947, the ratio reduced to an abysmal low of 896 girls to 1,000 boys in 2015-17; now, the SRS shows an improvement to 918 girls to 1,000 boys in 2022-24. Good news, but still way below the ratio at Independence, which is also the World Health Organisation's reported biologically expected level.

An annual ritual takes place on October 11, when the world commemorates the Day

of the Girl Child. However, my wife and I see every day as a blessing, for we have two lovely daughters and a chirpy granddaughter in our midst. The start to our happiness was slightly odd, though.

It was 1981, and we were excited as our first child was about to be born. I was ready with a handheld bulky "two-in-one" (a transistor plus cassette recorder) outside the operating theatre (OT) of a Jammu hospital as the child was being delivered by C-section. Why the two-in-one? Well, it was just a would-be father's fad that the first cry of the child should be recorded for listening later in life as my wife and I aged.

We were waiting with sweets outside the OT as a nurse exited and hurried away. A second one did the same. We were worried now.

Then, out came the gynaecologist and said, "Anyway, congratulations — it's a girl." We were overjoyed. The "anyway", however, rankles to this day, 45 years later. No hospital staff asked for sweets, as is the custom. We had to literally force them to accept it.

Our second girl came from a Gauhati hospital. And as my wife drifted in and out of anaesthesia after C-section, she asked for the child. But nobody would tell her anything — "*sab theek hai*", was the only response. Fi-

Social mores have changed over the past decades, but have attitudes toward a girl child changed for the better?

nally, she yelled and was shown the baby girl. No one asked for sweets here, either. What a welcome for a girl child.

Social mores have changed, but have attitudes toward a girl child changed for the better? The joint family has given way to a nuclear one. The "*hum do hamare do*" drive — whose logo was a sketch of a set of parents holding hands of a boy and a girl — spearheaded the family planning drive in the last century but is invisible now. The admirable "*beti bachao beti padhao*" drive started in 2015 seems to have faded. Modern technology has benefitted the medical field immensely, with the average lifespan in India increasing from 32 years in 1947 to 72 in 2022. However, the same technology has been used for female foeticide — the re-

cent arrest in Pune of some doctors and a Class XII dropout moving around with a portable sonography probe attached to an app for sex determination tests makes for frightful reading.

Another October 11 will soon come, as will platitudes spewed by politicians extolling the girl child as a goddess incarnate. But the ground reality is what counts. The sex ratio at birth, as per the SRS data, is slightly better in urban areas than in rural belts, indicating that education may well be key to protecting the female child. Leaders of religion, thought, politics, and social standing must redouble their efforts to ensure that the Viksit Bharat drive stays a balanced one.

The writer is a retired air vice marshal

'Anyway, It's a Girl' — 45 Years Later, It Still Rankles

● The Data

- Latest SRS (Sample Registration System) 2024 data raises concern for the national drive to protect the girl child
- **Sex ratio at birth: 952 female births per 1,000 male births in 1947 → fell to an abysmal 896:1,000 in 2015-17 → improved to 918:1,000 now — still well below the ratio at Independence and the WHO's biologically expected level**
- The sex ratio at birth is slightly better in urban areas than in rural belts, suggesting education may be key to protecting the female child

● What Has Changed, What Hasn't

- The joint family has given way to the nuclear family; average life expectancy in India rose from 32 years (1947) to 72 years (2022) thanks to medical advances
- The same medical technology has also been used for female foeticide

● The Way Forward

- Ground reality, not rhetoric, is what counts : the annual observance of the **International Day of the Girl Child (October 11)** is often followed by political platitudes
- Leaders across religion, thought, politics and social standing must redouble efforts to ensure India's Viksit Bharat (developed India) drive remains a gender-balanced one

Topics to be covered later :
India - New Zealand FTA
Venezuela Earthquake

Thank You